

The Green Lord's Court

Tier	Tier 2
Party Level	Up to 7 PCs at Level 6 — the Site-C milestone is applied between sessions ; rebuild sheets to L6 before play. The marked four (Fiorn, Yinu, Naan, Nalith) plus Dirk are the core; Kto returns if Caitlin is back. Combat is sized for 6×L6 (see file 2).
Duration	~2 hours of play
Setting	The dying heart of the Living Wood — the Hawthorn Gate at the contracting seam, then through the seam into the court of the Green Lord
Hook From	Session 005 — <i>The Thorn Lord's Summons</i> (the two-day audience; the marked party walking into the wood's greying center; Sela's broken pact)



Adventure Summary

This is the audience Session 005 walked toward and cut before — delivered at last, in **two acts and roughly two hours**. The party is at the greying center of the Living Wood with **Sela Wyndmere** between them, the seam contracting to a single bright point ahead. **Act One is the gate: Maelorn the Thorn Ward** holds the seam-door and runs the trial the Court owes every guest — a measuring, not a killing, that **collapses into ceremony if Nalith still carries Quillip's hawthorn berry**, and that forces a choice on the unmarked sixth, **Dirk**. **Act Two is the table:** through the door, the party is received by the lord himself — **Oberon, the Green Lord**, named at last — gracious, ancient, and generous, laying a feast and offering the marked an eternal place at his court. The grace **is** the harvest. The same slow pull that emptied the wood is now closing on the party, and the "taken children" of Shadowdale are already here, woven smiling into the hall.

The session lands on **Sela's redemption**. She tied twelve years of stitching that let Oberon reel the wood in; she is the only one who can **cut it** — and the fey healing he loaned her is the thread she has to spend to do it. She gives her life to sever the seam from inside, breaking the lord's hold on the party. But the binding collapses the door, and instead of the road home the backlash **hurls the party through the failing seam into the raw Feywild**. Hard cut. Sela is gone; the company is alive, free, cheated Oberon of his catch — and lost in his world.

Flag: DM — Scope is deliberately two acts

This session is **the gate and the table** — **nothing past the threshold**. Do **not** play out the Feywild on the far side; the tumble through is the closing image, and where they land is **Session 007's** problem. If the table is flying, end early rather than starting an act you can't finish. The point of the night is Oberon's reveal and **Sela's death**, not a third location.

PART ONE — The Gate

~50 minutes. The last mile, the gatekeeper's trial, and the door.

Scene 1 — The Last Mile

Setup

Pick up exactly where Session 005 cut: the party deep in the Living Wood, the color drained out of everything, **Sela Wyndmere** walking point the way she'd walk a sick-room. Ahead the grey thins into a hard line, and past it — the only living color left in the forest — two great hawthorns lean together over a doorway made of standing light.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud

*You have been walking the wrong way down the road out of town for an hour, and the wood has been dying around you the whole way — color first, then birdsong, then warmth. Now the grey ends like a held breath. Past the last dead trees the ground rises into a ring of moss-furred standing stones, and at its center two ancient hawthorns have grown together overhead, white with the only blossom left in the world. Beneath them the air **stands up like water on its end** — a doorway of green-gold light, pulled tight and bright and breathing. Sela stops at the treeline and does not take another step. "This is as far as I have ever been let," she says, very quietly. "He has never let me see the door."*

(Player handout: **The Hawthorn Gate** — see the-green-lords-court-3-player-handouts.md.)

Three Things Before the Gate (keep it to ~10 minutes)

The party has eleven loose threads in their packs; do **not** relitigate them here. Land at most these three quick reorientation beats and move to the gate:

- **The seam is closing on a clock.** Any **Arcana DC 13** (Yinu +11) confirms what Yinu read last session: the seam is still contracting, faster now, drawing toward the bright point under the arch. *Whatever is going to happen happens on the far side, and the door will not stand open forever.*
- **Sela has come to the end of her road — and means to go further.** She was only ever the courier; she has never crossed. Now she intends to. If asked why: *"Because he should have to say it to my face. And because I tied the knots that are strangling this wood. If there's a thread to cut, I won't have you cutting it blind."* (Foreshadows her arc; do not explain it.)
- **Quillip is not here yet.** The pixie did not come to the bonfire and has not appeared on the walk. If the party calls for her, a single hawthorn leaf spirals down with a knot tied in its stem — *she is near the gate, and she is afraid to come closer.* (She turns up at the gate, Scene 2.)

Flag: DM — Don't re-run Session 5

*Yinu's Harper book, Naan's Lathander letter, the Vhaeraunian clock — all still live, all **off the table tonight**. If a player reaches for one, one sentence of acknowledgment and back to the door. The compulsion is pulling them forward; let the scene pull too.*

What This Scene Locks In

- The party is **at the gate** with Sela, the seam visibly contracting on a clock.
- Sela has declared she is **crossing** — the Thornward's *"bring her"* (S5 prep) is hereby honored by her own choice.
- The door is the only way on, and the gatekeeper is about to step out of it.

Scene 2 — The Hawthorn Gate

~35 minutes. The trial the Court owes every guest. Combat, ceremony, or both.

Setup

As the party approaches the arch, the light parts and the gatekeeper steps out of it. This is the gate-trial **prepped for Session 005 and never reached** — run it now. It is a **measuring, not a killing**: Maelorn pulls every blow, yields the instant the party shows him something worth naming, and **collapses the whole thing into one ceremonial round if Nalith spends Quillip's hawthorn berry**.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — The Thorn Ward

The doorway of light parts, and the knight who rode a stag into your festival steps out of it on foot — bark and bronze, a helm of living silver branches, a glaive whose head is a single black thorn. You know him. He plants the glaive. "I am Maelorn, Thorn Ward of this gate. My lord has marked you, and the marked are tested before they are met. I will not aim to kill —" the thorn lowers until it points at the boldest of you — so do not insult me by dying."

(Player handout: **Maelorn, the Thorn Ward** — see the-green-lords-court-3-player-handouts.md. Full statblock, tactics, the parley triggers, and the berry shortcut are in the-green-lords-court-2-combat-tracker.md, Encounter 1.)

Quillip Arrives — and the Berry Pays Off

As the trial begins, **Quillip Burr-and-Whistle** uncurls from a hawthorn branch, more rattled than she lets on. This is the **payoff slot** for the S4 token that S5 never spent.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — Quillip

*"You came. Good. Bad. Both." The pixie drops to Nalith's shoulder, wings the color of the seam. "That's the Thorn Ward, and the door's question has a blade in it — he has to, the Court is watching and he will **not** be embarrassed." She glances at the contracting light and her banter thins. "You still have my berry? The hawthorn one? Now would be the time, sweetling. Save your blood for what's on the other side. You'll want it."*

Quillip's Own Crossing (a small, optional beat — ~1 minute)

Quillip has dropped tokens, traded songs, and turned up at festivals — but she has **never once gone through the door**, and she is more afraid of it than her chatter admits (roster: *lonely in a way she would never admit; fears being forgotten*). Give her a beat of real choice once the gate resolves: does she dart back to the safe grey treeline, or follow the party through the seam into the lord's hall? She will not decide for free — she wants a reason.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — Quillip at the Threshold

*The pixie hovers at the very edge of the standing light, and for once she isn't joking. "I don't go in there. Nobody who goes in there comes back the same, and I like being **me**, thank you." Her little wings buzz, indecisive. "...But you'll walk in there and forget to be afraid, and someone has to remember to be afraid **for** you." She looks at the closing seam, then at Nalith. "Tell me to come and I'll come. Don't make me decide it alone."*

Flag: DM — Quillip's choice (seeds her into Act Two and S7)

If any PC invites her, Quillip crosses with the party — a frightened, loyal, very useful set of fey eyes inside Oberon's hall (she'll hiss the fey-law tells in Scene 3 — eat nothing, promise nothing — and can be the one who survives the fall into the Feywild beside them; see Scene 4's closing and Loot & Rewards). **If no one invites her**, she stays at the treeline, calls one last warning after them, and is **gone when they're pulled through** — a thread left in the material world. Either way, her loneliness made visible costs the table nothing and pays off her arc. Let the players' choice stand.

Flag: DM — Quillip's hawthorn berry (the S4 token, paid off here at last)

If Nalith **presents the berry** (shows it to the Thorn Ward or presses it to the arch), the gate-challenge collapses into pure ceremony — Maelorn lowers his glaive, the "fight" is one symbolic round of crossed blades, and the party is received as **invited guests** rather than trespassers being tested. **The berry vouches for the whole party at the arch — Dirk included** ("vouched by the wood's own"). If Nalith lost, ate, or planted the berry — no problem; run the full trial. Either way it ends in a yield, never a kill. See the combat tracker for both branches.

The Unmarked Sixth (Dirk's beat — run it before or during the trial)

The mark is on four (Fiorn, Yinu, Naan, Nalith); **Dirk was on a barge when it landed**, and fey law does not round up. Maelorn will not pretend otherwise.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — The Thorn Ward and Dirk

*The antlered helm turns to Dirk and the knight inhales once, like a man reading weather. "Four my lord has marked. This one carries no mark, no invitation, and no debt — river-blood, walked into a leaving wood for people met a day ago." A pause that might be approval. "The marked are tested because they are expected. **You** are tested because you are interesting. Stand with them and be measured — or stand aside, and the gate has no quarrel with you."*

Let Ari make the call. Standing with the party means Dirk is measured alongside everyone and **counted through the door** with the rest. Standing aside is safe and Maelorn genuinely holds no grudge — but Dirk then has **no safe-conduct across the seam** and watches from the treeline with Sela's old limit. (The berry covers Dirk too, if Nalith spends it.) No kid will pick to stay behind — but the *choice* is what makes crossing mean something.

What the Trial Measures

The fight is a **question, not a slaughter**. Maelorn pulls killing blows (a downed PC drops to 1 HP and prone — "the flat of the thorn"), and he **kneels and names the party worthy when bloodied or at the end of Round 3**. What the party shows him — courage, restraint, cleverness, mercy — he carries through the door ahead of them, and it **colors how Oberon receives them** in Act Two (track it; see file 4).

Even the berry shortcut produces a verdict. If Nalith spends the berry and the trial collapses to one ceremonial round, Maelorn still *reads* the party in that single crossed-blades salute — the gate exists to measure, and the measure is the thing he carries to his lord. Pick the verdict from how they've carried themselves all session (gracious / clever / wary / swaggering); it still sets Oberon's opening warmth. The berry buys past the *fight*, not past the *measuring*.

DM — track the verdict (it's spoken aloud in Scene 3). Note the one word or phrase Maelorn would use for this party: *unbroken and unbloodied, merciful, clever, brave, or — if they killed him — poachers.* He delivers it to Oberon's face when they cross (see Scene 3 setup). This is the gate's payoff made tangible at the table instead of hand-waved off-screen.

Flag: DM — Do NOT kill the Thorn Ward, and don't let him kill a PC

*If the party murders the gatekeeper, the audience curdles before it starts — Oberon receives them as poachers, not guests, and the harvest in Act Two loses its velvet (he need not be gracious to meat). Ceremonial Restraint catches any PC at 1 HP; narrate the thorn turning flat. The trial has a yield ramp every round — take it the moment they've shown him something. **Maelorn then escorts them through the seam himself** — walking in with them rather than reporting from a distance — and the door does not let Sela's old limit stop her now; she crosses with them. (His spoken verdict to Oberon lands in Scene 3.)*

What This Scene Locks In

- The party is **received** — tested (or vouched via the berry) and judged worthy; Maelorn's read of them precedes them through the door.

- **Dirk's standing is settled** — counted through, or holding at the treeline by choice.
- **The party crosses the seam** into the court — and **Sela crosses with them**, past the limit she has lived inside for twelve years.

PART TWO — The Green Lord's Table

~60 minutes. The welcome, the lord, the harvest, and the cut.

Scene 3 — The Court Received

Setup

Through the seam, the dying grey is gone. The party stands inside the **bright center** — a hall woven from living hawthorn grown into vaulting arches, every surface hung with white blossom and green-white-bone ribbon, warm gold light pouring from nowhere. Music. The smell of every good thing. And on a throne of antler, root, and iron-grey thornwood, before the seam now shrunk to a shining vertical thread behind him, **the lord of the wood is waiting** — and he rises, smiling, to meet them like family.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud

*You step through the standing water of the door and the dying world falls away behind you. Here it is **spring without end** — a hall of living hawthorn vaulted overhead like a cathedral grown rather than built, white with blossom, warm with a light that has no source. Long tables stand laid with a feast that steams. Pipes and strings play something just past the edge of a song you almost know. And from a throne of antler and root and grey thorn, before a thread of green-gold light pulled thin behind him, a tall fey lord rises — beautiful and ancient, crowned in antler and blossom, eyes like sunlight through leaves — and spreads his arms as though you are the guests he has waited an age to seat. "There you are," he says, warm as a hearth. "Come in, come in. You are most welcome at my table. I have wanted to thank you for a long while."*

(Player handout: **Oberon, the Green Lord** — see the-green-lords-court-3-player-handouts.md.)

Maelorn's Verdict (deliver it the moment they cross — the gate's payoff, spoken to the lord's face)

Maelorn walked in with them; before Oberon says a word more, the Thorn Ward plants his glaive and **reports the party's measure aloud** — the read he took at the gate, now made tangible at the table. Pick the line from the verdict you tracked in Scene 2. This is *why* the gate mattered: Oberon's warmth in the next beat visibly follows from it.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — The Thorn Ward Reports

The antlered knight crosses behind you and kneels once at the foot of the throne. "My lord. I measured them at your gate." And then — pick one:

The Gracious Lord (play him warm — the menace is that he is never not warm)

This is **Oberon, the Green Lord** — an archfey of the wild wood, one of the old and powerful ones, lord of beasts and the green. He **names himself** at his own table (the reserved S5+ reveal, paid here). Play him as the perfect host: gracious, funny, flattering, generous. He thanks the party sincerely for sealing the drow cleft beneath Old Skull — *"You kept the spiders out of my wood; do you imagine I did not notice?"* He seats them, toasts them, draws each one out by name and gift.

Give a beat or two to the table — proof he has been **watching** through twelve years of Sela's ribbons:

Each thread is a **temptation aimed at a thing the player already wants** — a live S4–S5 hook turned into an offer. Don't relitigate the hook; just let Oberon dangle it, then move on. (The point is that *saying yes would actually solve something* for that PC — that's the hook in the velvet.)

PC	His thread — <i>the offer behind the compliment</i>
Fiorn	"I dropped a fey-primrose on your table at the Greening, bard, to hear what you'd make of it. You named it true and played me a falling song." Then, lower: "Your touring elf would have you carry his bags down a muddy road for a season. I offer you an audience that never tires, never leaves, and never forgets a single verse. Sing here, and be sung of forever." (Trumps Helbrin's road-tour offer.)
Yinu	"You read my wood better than the wizard who sleeps in your Silverhand farm." A pause. "You were given a little cipher-book and told it was 'a key, not a recruitment.' Sweet of them. I read every letter that crosses my wood — every cipher, every dead-drop, every secret the Harpers think is theirs. Stay, and read it all from the inside." (Trumps the Harper cipher / Orvyn's 'key'.)
Naan	"A little daughter of the dawn, at my green table. Your Morninglord's people in Highmoon wrote you a letter — did you know I read every letter that passes my wood?" He smiles. "They ask you to choose one light and walk to it. Stay, and you need never choose between two lights again — mine is the nearer, and it does not set." (Trumps the Lathander/Highmoon invitation.)
Nalith	"You carry one of my hawthorn's own berries and you did not spend it to harm my Ward. A guest's instinct." Then, gently: "You spend yourself patching a dale that buries its scouts and forgets your name by spring. Here, no one you tend ever dies. Heal a hall where healing always wins. You were always going to sit here." (Trumps the thankless-healer thread; pairs with Sela's Scene 4 goodbye.)
Dirk	"And the river brought me one I did not call. Unmarked, uninvited, and here anyway. The wood likes a thing it did not plan." A nod, almost fond. "You live on a raft on a borrowed river, sailor, one flood from nothing. I have a river that never floods and beer that does not run out. Sit. No one here asks where you came from." (Aimed at Dirk's rootless drifter angle.)
Kto (if present)	"You were not at the bonfire when my Ward marked your friends, archer — and you came anyway, after them, into a leaving wood. Loyalty is a coin I honor." Then: "Your long war with the spider-folk is over and it cost you a blade's worth of grief. I have hunts that never end and quarry that never runs out. Sit at my hand." (Nods to her closed Zeldrazz vendetta.)

Then the **offer**, laid like a gift:

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — The Offer

"Here is what I would give you," the Green Lord says, and the whole bright hall leans in to listen. "A place. This table, this spring, this hall — forever, and no winter in it. You have spent yourselves for a grey little dale that pays you in copper and errands. I pay in **eternity**. Stay. Be mine, and be honored, and never grow old or afraid again." He smiles, and it is the warmest thing you have seen all day. "Say yes. It is such an easy word."

The Harvest Behind the Grace

The offer **is** the harvest. Everything Sela confessed — the slow pull, the taken children, the emptied wood — converges here: Oberon does not *steward* the green, he **gathers** it, reeling whole living things into his domain to be his forever, smiling and hollow. Once the seam finishes contracting, **everything inside the hall is gathered with it** — saying "yes" only makes it gracious. Seed the tell; let the players find it:

Beat	Check	What it reveals
The other guests	Insight DC 14 (Naan, Fiorn) or Perception DC 15	The hall is full of guests — fey, beasts, and <i>people</i> : farmfolk, a peddler, children in season-old Shadowdale clothes — all smiling, all still, all <i>slightly wrong</i> , like portraits of themselves. None of them have left this table in a very long time. (Sela goes white: " <i>Those are the children. The ones the wood 'took.'</i> Gods, they're all still here.")
The thread behind the throne	Arcana DC 15 (Yinu +11)	The seam is now a single contracting thread, anchored to the throne — and anchored to the party , fine green-gold filaments hooked into the mark on the four. When it closes, it does not send anyone home; it reels them in . <i>Saying yes just stops you pulling against the line.</i>
The feast	Survival/Nature DC 13 , or any fey-lore	The food is real and the warmth is real and that is the trap — eat nothing, promise nothing . A guest who takes the lord's bread by his own word is <i>gathered</i> by consent. (Classic fey law; Quillip will hiss it if no one rolls it.)
Oberon himself	Insight DC 17 (hard)	He is not lying and never has been. He genuinely means the gift. That is what makes him terrible: to Oberon, being gathered into his eternal court is kindness. He will not rage if refused — he will simply let the door finish closing, because the line is already set.
Sela's ribbons in the court	Investigation DC 14 or Sela's own recognition (automatic if she is present)	The ribbons woven through the hall — green, white, bone — are Sela's knots . She tied them. And some are not just stitching: they are messages , still legible in the knot-pattern, words she carried and never read. One cluster near the throne is older than the rest, the knots tighter, the ribbon sun-faded: a message she carried years ago . Sela goes still. " <i>Those are mine. I tied those. And I never... I never read what was in them.</i> " (Sets up the drow-intelligence reveal in Scene 4.)

Sela's ribbons are the bridge to the drow plot. If the party spots the tell above (or even if they don't — Sela will notice her own knots), seed the realization that the ribbons weren't *only* stitching. Some carried **words** — Oberon's instructions to fey wardens who watched the passages beneath Old Skull. Sela carried drow intelligence for years without knowing

it. Do **not** reveal the content here; save it for Scene 4, when Sela reads the knots as she cuts. The beat in Scene 3 is just the *recognition* — her knots are in the court, and they say things she never read.

Flag: DM — Oberon is not a combat encounter. Do not stat him; do not let them fight him.

The Green Lord is an **archfey in the heart of his own power**. There is no statblock in file 2 for him **on purpose**. If the party attacks, he does **not** deign to fight — he sighs, the music keeps playing, and the **seam contracts a stage faster** (advance the Harvest Clock; see file 4). Steel does nothing here. The only handle on this room is the **binding** — and the only hand that can reach it is Sela's. Steer the table off "kill him" and onto "the line, the thread, the ribbons." Quillip, Maelorn (if befriended), or Sela can all say it plainly: "You cannot cut him. You can only cut the line."

The Bargain Floor (if the party negotiates instead of refusing flat)

Oberon **loves** a bargain — it is more binding than a feast. He will dicker, graciously, and every deal is a hook for later sessions (or a trap now). Full matrix in file 4; the shape:

- **He will let them leave** — for a price: a name, a memory, a firstborn season, a return at the next turning. Any such deal is real fey contract law; **don't let it be free, and write down what they promised**.
- **He will release the taken children** — but only in trade for someone to take their place at the table. (This is the door Sela walks through in Scene 4.)
- **He will not** give back the years he has already gathered, and he will not let the *whole* catch go for nothing. The line is set; something has to pay it out.

What the Party CAN Change (agency inside a fixed climax)

The ending is fixed — **Sela cuts the line, Sela dies, the party falls into the Feywild** — and the prep rightly steers off "kill Oberon" and "out-pull the line." But a fixed *ending* is not a railroad if the players have real levers on its *terms*. Make these explicit so the table never feels like they're only watching a cutscene. Every one of these is something their choices genuinely decide:

What they can change	How	Why it matters
Oberon's lasting disposition	Refuse flat / bargain / threaten / play along — <i>and</i> the gate verdict	Sets the Green Lord's stance toward them the next time the wood and the party cross (S7+). A debt owed both ways takes its shape here
Whether the taken children go free	Press Oberon for their release (a bargain), or open the gap Sela's cut creates and <i>hold it</i> long enough for them to pour through	If the party doesn't act, the cut still breaks the harvest — but the children's clean escape is their win, not an automatic one
What they promise (or refuse to promise)	Every bargain is real fey-contract law	What they owe Oberon follows them into the Feywild and back. Refusing a tempting deal is its own act of agency
Whether Sela's last message is fully read	Help her decode the old knot (Scene 4 — a check, or simply guarding her the extra beat)	Determines how <i>complete</i> the drow-intelligence the party carries out is (see Scene 4)
Who stands with Sela, and how she's witnessed	Stand at the throne with her, a word, a hand, Fiorn's <i>Falling</i> played one last time	Costs nothing mechanically; it's the emotional core of the night and the thing the log remembers

DM — **say yes to clever non-combat plays**. If the party tries something inventive that isn't attacking Oberon — cutting other ribbons to slow the reel, using a spell to shield Sela's work, talking a gathered child into moving, spending Quillip's banked boon — **let it matter** within the fixed frame: it can buy a round, free another captive,

or harden the party's standing. The one thing that never works is steel on the lord. Everything short of that is on the table.

What This Scene Locks In

- **Oberon, the Green Lord, is named** — the reserved reveal, paid at his own table.
- The party understands the **welcome is the harvest**: the seam reels them in when it closes; the taken children are already here; eating or consenting completes the gather.
- The only lever in the room is the **binding** Sela tied — setting up her sacrifice. **But the terms of that sacrifice are the party's to shape** (the children, the promises, the message, the witness).

Scene 4 — The Last Ribbon

Setup

The seam is a hand's-breadth from closing. Whatever the party has tried — refusal, bargain, a doomed swing at a god — the line is set and reeling, and they can feel the hooks in the mark drawing them toward the throne. And **Sela Wyndmere** steps forward, past the party, to the foot of the throne she served blind for twelve years, with the last spool of ribbon in her hands.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — Sela at the Throne

*Sela walks to the foot of the throne the way she walked into the wood — quiet, certain, watching the patient. She looks up at the Green Lord, and for the first time all day she is not afraid. "You gave me healing," she says, "and I gave you twelve years of knots, and never once read what I was tying. I read it now. Every ribbon I left was a stitch, and I sewed this wood into your hand a thread at a time. The children. The droughts. Them —" she does not look at the still, smiling guests "— I did that. Carrying your words." Her hands move to the ribbons woven through the throne's roots, and she stops. Her fingers find a knot she tied **years** ago — and her face changes. "These weren't all stitches," she whispers. "Some of these were **messages**. Real words. I was carrying — gods, I was carrying **intelligence** and I never —" She lifts the last knot of green, white, and bone. "So I'll carry one more. My own. And I'll read this one to them first, because they'll need it where they're going."*

Reading the Knot Together (refinement — let a PC help her decode it)

The message is in Sela's ribbon-cipher, but the hall is unravelling and her hands are failing as the healing pours out of her. **Let a PC help her finish reading it** — it makes the party *participants* in the discovery rather than an audience to a monologue, and it ties Scene 3's ribbon-recognition tell straight into this payoff.

- **The simplest version:** anyone who steadies her hands or holds the ribbon taut lets her read it in full — no roll, just the choice to help.
- **The rollable version:** **Yinu** (Arcana, to parse the binding-script) or **Fiorn/anyone** (Investigation, to read the knot-pattern) at **DC 13** surfaces the *whole* message clearly. On a help/success, Sela reads every line below. **On a failure or if no one helps**, she gets only the *fragment* — she gasps out "*the masked ones... the spider-ones... a third cleft they never found—*" and the rest is lost as the seam takes her. The party still carries the gist, but the precise wording (and the "river-stone / do not let them past" detail) is theirs only if a PC helped her read it.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — The Last Message

As Sela's fingers work the old knot open — a PC's hands steadying hers — the ribbon-language unravels into words only she can read, and she speaks them aloud, fast, because the hall is coming apart around her and she is running out of time. "This one's four years old. I carried it to the hollow hawthorn and never knew what it said." She reads:

"The dark ones dig beneath the skull-stone. The masked ones open mouths in the rock; the spider-ones close

them. Both are ours to watch, not ours to fight. Hold the green at the river-stone and do not let them past the third cleft. If the stitching holds, the wood holds."

She looks at the party, and the understanding hits her like the healing leaving her body. "He wasn't just gathering. He was **watching** them. The drow. Under Old Skull. His wardens were holding them back, and I was the — I was the **thread** that held the line, and I never knew." The knot dissolves in her fingers. "The stitching's broken now. I broke it. And when this cut lands, there's nothing holding that third cleft at all."

Flag: DM — The drow-intelligence tie (connects S6 to the S1–S3 drow arc)

This is the bridge between the fey arc and the drow arc. Sela's twelve years of unread messages weren't only the harvest-stitching — some were **Oberon's instructions to fey wardens** who monitored the drow passages beneath Old Skull. The "masked ones" are the **Vhaeraunians** (silver half-masks, S1–S3); the "spider-ones" are the **Lolthites** (S2). The "**third cleft**" is a deeper passage the party has never found — below the three staging sites they already cleared. The implication: Oberon's fey were a containment perimeter, and Sela's ribbons were part of it. By breaking the pact (S5) and cutting the binding (S6), the party has **removed that containment**. When they return from the Feywild, the drow situation beneath Old Skull will be worse than they left it. **The party carries this intelligence into the Feywild** — it's the one piece of Sela's legacy that isn't spent by her death.

Sela Cuts the Line (the climax — give it room)

Sela is the **instrument of the harvest** — and therefore the only one who can unmake it. The fey healing Oberon loaned her twelve years ago is a **thread of the wood's own life woven into her**; the pact made her a living knot in his binding. She can cut the line — by **spending that thread**, giving back every borrowed year at once. It will sever the seam from the inside and break Oberon's hold on the party. It will also **kill her**. She knows. She does it anyway.

Run it as **her** moment, not a check the party can roll for her — but give the table agency *around* it:

- **The party cannot save her and stop the harvest both.** Make that clear if they try (Insight, or Quillip, or Maelorn): "The line needs a life to pay it out. She is offering hers. You can spend it, or you can all be spent. There is no third knot." If a PC tries to take her place, she refuses — "You have years left to grow old badly. I spent mine. Let me spend them well." (If a player **insists** on a heroic substitution, that's a table call — but the intended, prepped, and far stronger beat is **Sela's death**. Steer hard toward letting her have it.)
- **What the party CAN do:** stand with her, guard her as she works (Oberon does not rage, but the hall itself resists — vines, the still guests stirring, the seam thrashing), free the taken children through the gap she opens, and witness her — a kind word, a hand, Fiorn's falling song played one last time. Mark who stands with her; it matters to her and to the log.
- **A goodbye, not just a death — give Sela one last line to someone.** Her strongest played bond is with **Nalith** (S4: Sela judged the Greening, praised her healing — "You must be a skilled healer" — and pinned her the gold ribbon; the same moment Quillip slipped her the berry). Aim the goodbye there if Nalith is at the throne; fall back to **Fiorn** (the *Falling* song, the primrose) or whoever stood closest. Don't let the death land on the party-in-general when it can land on a *face*.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — Sela's Goodbye (to Nalith, or whoever stands closest)

The healing is already leaving her — the white streak in her hair going pure silver, her hands going to light. She finds Nalith's eyes. "I pinned a gold ribbon on you at the Greening and told you you were a skilled healer. I meant it. You're the one this wood actually needed — I was only ever the courier." A breath. "Don't carry messages you won't read. Promise me that much." (If Nalith isn't there, she says it to Fiorn — "Play me the falling song. You named it before either of us knew what it meant." — or to whoever held her hand.)

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — The Cut

She unties the knot. It is the smallest motion — a healer's fingers, sure and gentle — and the whole hall **screams**. Green-gold light pours out of Sela, not into her, twelve years given back in a single breath; the ribbon

dissolves into motes, and every other ribbon in the hall begins to unravel with it, the whole woven court coming apart at the seams she sewed. On his throne the Green Lord does not rage. He watches the line he set fray in the hands of the one who tied it, and something almost like respect crosses his ancient face. "Ah," says Oberon softly. "The courier reads at last." The seam behind him blows open like a held breath finally let go — and it does **not** open onto the road home.

The Tumble (the closing image — then cut)

The binding collapses. Oberon's hold on the party breaks — they are not gathered. But the seam, unmade from inside, does not deposit them gently back in the grey wood; the backlash **tears the door wide and pulls them through it the wrong way**, down the drain Sela just unplugged, into the bright wrong country on the far side. **Sela is not with them.** She gave the last of herself to the cut, and the unmaking took her with it — she is gone, and the wood she died to free is already greening behind the closing tear.

DM — one thing falls with them (an S7 cold-open anchor). The party tumbles into the Feywild with more than "no idea where the bottom is" — give the far side **one concrete thing** to grab onto, so S7 has a hook the moment it opens. Use whichever fits the table:

Name the object/companion now; do not narrate where it (or they) land. The anchor is for the S7 opening, not for tonight.

Read-aloud: Read Aloud — Closing

The floor of the world goes out from under you. The hall comes apart — blossom and ribbon and grey-thorn throne unravelling into light — and the last thing you see in it is Sela Wyndmere, lit from inside, lifting one hand toward you that is already coming apart into petals. Then the door has you. Not the road home. Not the grey wood. Something **brighter** — falling color and impossible distance and a sky the wrong number of colors — and you are falling into it, all of you together — a healer's last gift burning in your chests, (if Quillip crossed: a small terrified pixie shrieking and clinging to someone's collar,) (and/or: a single strand of green-white-bone ribbon wound tight around one wrist, the last thing Sela ever tied,) a wood saved at your backs, and absolutely no idea where the bottom is.

(End of session. Where they land is Session 007.)

Flag: DM — End on the fall. Do not narrate the landing.

The image is the tumble through into the Feywild — brightness, wrongness, together, falling. **Stop there.** Resist every urge to describe where they come down; that first breath of the far side is the cold open of the next session, and it's worth more unspent. If players ask "where are we?" — "You'll find out when you land." Cut to black.

What This Scene Locks In

- **Sela Wyndmere is dead** — redemptively, by her own choice, undoing twelve years of complicity and breaking Oberon's hold on the party.
- **The harvest is broken** — the taken children freed (if the party opened the gap), the wood greening again, Oberon cheated of his catch.
- **The party is pulled through into the Feywild** — alive, free, together, and **lost** — carrying **one concrete anchor** into S7 (Quillip if she crossed, and/or the snagged strand of Sela's ribbon). The emergence is the S7 cold open.
- **Quillip's choice is settled** — she crossed with them (invited) or was left at the treeline (not). Either outcome is a live S7 thread.
- **Oberon survives, un-defeated and un-fought** — his court unmade but his person untouched. A debt is now owed in both directions. (Long-term thread.)

- **Drow intelligence carried into the Feywild** — Sela's last message reveals Oberon's fey wardens were monitoring (and containing) the drow beneath Old Skull; the "**third cleft**" is a deeper passage the party has never found; and the fey containment is now broken along with the harvest. The party carries this knowledge with them — Sela's final gift alongside the cut.

Loot & Rewards Summary

Currency / Tangible

- **No paymaster across the seam** — this is a fey audience, not a contract. Lady Ulphor's promised settlement (S5) is owed *if the party ever gets home to collect it*.
- **Quillip's hawthorn berry** — if **spent at the gate** (Scene 2), it's gone, having bought the ceremonial bypass. If **unused**, Nalith carries it into the Feywild — still a one-shot Bright Court guest-token, and possibly worth more on the far side than it ever was here.
- **Quillip herself** — *if a PC invited her across (Scene 2)*. Not loot, but the party's single most valuable carry-forward: a frightened, loyal fey ally pulled into the Feywild *with* them. If she stayed at the treeline, she's a thread left behind in the material world. (See the S7 cold-open anchor flag, Scene 4.)
- **A strand of the lord's ribbon** — **Sela's last knotwork** (*if used as the S7 anchor, Scene 4*). Green-white-bone, snagged on whoever stood closest to Sela as the court unravelled. Still legible to anyone who learns the cipher; **DM discretion** whether it still carries *quest-right* in the Feywild. The one physical relic of Sela the party keeps.
- **Sela's kit** — whatever poultices/antitoxin remain from her S5 gift are all the party now carries of her. (*Sentiment, and a few HP.*)
- **The freed** — if the party opened the gap for the taken children, they pour back through the closing tear toward Shadowdale. The party does **not** get to escort them home (the party goes the *other* way); their return is a thread Shadowdale will feel while the PCs are gone.

Boons / Intangible

- **Sela's gift** — the light of her cut passes *through* the party on the way out. DM discretion for an S7 boon: a one-time fey blessing, a lingering scrap of her healing, or simply the wood's goodwill carried into a hostile plane. Define it when S7 opens.
- **Sela's last message (drow intelligence)** — the one piece of Sela's legacy not spent by her death. The party now knows: (1) Oberon's fey wardens were monitoring the drow beneath Old Skull for years; (2) the "masked ones" (Vhaeraunians) and "spider-ones" (Lolthites) were both under fey observation; (3) a "**third cleft**" — a deeper passage below the three staging sites the party already cleared — exists and was held by fey wardens; (4) that containment is now **broken** along with the binding. This intelligence follows the party into the Feywild and back, and sets up the drow situation they'll return to in S7+.
- **Oberon's measure** — track *how* the party handled his table: refused flat, bargained (and what they promised), swung at him, or were saved before they could choose. It sets the Green Lord's disposition toward them the next time the wood and the party cross — and fey lords have long memories.

XP / Milestone

- **Milestone earned** — **apply between sessions**. Surviving the audience, breaking the harvest, and crossing into the Feywild advances the party toward **Level 7**. Do **not** stage a level-up at the table (see Invariants). Rebuild sheets to L7 in downtime before S7 if you're milestone-leveling; flag it as *earned, applied later*.

DM Additions Flagged for Guide Canonization

Drafted here; enter into the campaign guide **before** play per the workflow (roster / factions / geography now; session-log waits until after the session is actually played).

- **Oberon, the Green Lord** — the fey lord of the Living Wood, **named at last**. An archfey of the wild wood (canonical D&D archfey; **not** detailed in the FR references, which are thin on named archfey — flag the provenance). Gracious, ancient, predatory; harvests living things into his eternal court. → campaign/roster.md and campaign/factions.md (§ Court of the Thorn Lord, now the Green Lord's court).
- **The Green Lord's court (across the seam)** — the hall of living hawthorn at the bright center of the seam, full of "gathered" guests including Shadowdale's taken children. → campaign/factions.md; the **far side is the Feywild itself** → campaign/geography.md (DM Additions, tagged (DM ADDITION)), seeded for the S7 arc.
- **Sela Wyndmere** — **died redemptively (S6, pending play)**. From penitent ally to **sacrifice**: spent her fey-loaned life to cut the binding and break the harvest. **Hold the roster status-flip to *deceased* until the session is actually played** (same gate as session-log) — but stage the entry now.
- **The Harvest Clock & "the line"** — promote the contracting-seam mechanic to a named device: the binding reels the marked in when it closes; only the courier who tied it can cut it. → faction note.
- **Maelorn the Thorn Ward** — **gate-trial played at last**. His prepped Ceremonial-Restraint trial finally runs here; note the outcome in the roster after play.
- **Oberon's fey-warden containment of the drow (the "third cleft")** — Sela's last message reveals Oberon's fey were monitoring and containing the drow beneath Old Skull for years; Sela's ribbons carried drow intelligence she never read. A **"third cleft"** — a deeper passage below the three Vhaeraunian staging sites (S1–S3) — was held by fey wardens and is now unheld. → campaign/factions.md (§ Drow Underdark Factions and § Fey of the Living Wood — cross-link the two); campaign/geography.md (the third cleft as a DM Addition under Old Skull). **Hold the session-log entry until after play** (same gate as Sela's death).

Flag: *Invented content to confirm with the user*

*New this session: **naming the lord Oberon** (canonical archfey, used here as the wood-lord — a permanent reveal), the harvest-court across the seam, Sela's redemptive death, and the party's crossing into the Feywild. Confirm before canonizing — especially the Oberon naming and Sela's death, both of which are hard to walk back once logged.*

Combat Tracker — The Green Lord's Court

One scripted encounter: the gate-trial the Court owes every guest. It is a **ceremonial test that ends in parley at bloodied / Round 3** — and collapses to a single symbolic round if Nalith spends Quillip's hawthorn berry. **Do not kill the Thorn Ward; do not let the Thorn Ward kill a PC.** Act Two (the court of Oberon) has **no combat** — the Green Lord is an archfey in the heart of his power and is **not** a fightable foe; there is intentionally no statblock for him. See file 1, Scene 3, and file 4 for the Harvest Clock that replaces a boss fight.

Encounter 1 — The Hawthorn Gate

Scene 2 · Medium-to-Hard (raw 2,200 XP → ~3,300 adjusted) · ceremonial test, parley at bloodied/R3 · 6×L6

Summary

Location	The Hawthorn Cleft — the contracting Feywild seam at the dying center of the Living Wood, twin hawthorns arched over a doorway of green-gold light, ringed by seven standing stones. The seam is the door to the Green Lord's court.
Light	Twilight-bright fey glow under the arch; flat grey daylight at the dead clearing's edge.
Terrain	The seam/ritual circle at center (north) — the Thorn Ward's whole job is to keep the party off it until they're judged. Standing stones (cover) ring the clearing; two toadstool rings (difficult terrain); a ribboned cairn to the east (cover). Forest path enters from the south; blossoming hedge walls the north behind the arch.
Antagonists	1× Maelorn, the Thorn Ward (CR 5, ■■■) + 2× Sprite Outrider (CR 1, owl-mounted — the same two from the S4 bonfire and the S5 prep, for continuity).
Party	6 PCs at Level 6 (Dirk is not marked — see <i>Triggers</i> ; Kto joins if Caitlin is present).
XP	Raw 2,200 → ×1.5 multi-foe at 6 PCs → ~3,300 adjusted (6×L6: Medium 3,600, Hard 5,400). Medium-to-Hard but scripted short — the Thorn Ward yields, he does not win. No rebalance needed; he was never trying to. With a 7th PC (Kto), it runs softer — fine.
Duration	3 rounds max. The Thorn Ward kneels and names the party worthy when bloodied (≤45) OR at end of Round 3 — whichever first.
Goal (PCs)	Show the Thorn Ward something worth naming — courage, restraint, cleverness, or mercy. Winning is not killing him; it is being judged worthy and crossing the door.
Goal (Thorn Ward)	Test, not kill. Measure these mortals, keep them off the seam, yield with honor when they've proven themselves, then escort them through.
Berry shortcut	If Nalith spends Quillip's hawthorn berry (shows/presses it to the arch), the Thorn Ward grounds his glaive — see <i>Triggers</i> . The fight becomes one symbolic round , no real combat. Covers Dirk.

Round Strip & Initiative

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

NPC initiative is pre-rolled (DEX-averaged). PCs roll live and write into the blank rows.

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
20	Sprite Outrider 1	15	22 □□□□□	Owl-mounted, 80 ft fly, hovering 60 ft up
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
17	Maelorn, the Thorn Ward	17	90 □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□	Bloodied 45 · Magic Resistance · pulls killing blows
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
12	Sprite Outrider 2	15	22 □□□□□	Owl-mounted, 80 ft fly, hovering 60 ft up
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **The Berry Shortcut (best outcome).** If Nalith presents Quillip's hawthorn berry at any point (action to show/press it to the arch), the Thorn Ward **immediately grounds his glaive**. Run **one symbolic round** — a single crossed-blades salute — then go straight through the door to Act Two. The Sprites stand down. *No real combat. The berry vouches for everyone at the arch — Dirk included ("vouched by the wood's own"). Even here, Maelorn still reads the party in that one round* — the gate exists to measure, and he carries a verdict (*berry-vouched*, plus however they've carried themselves) to Oberon's face in Scene 3. The berry buys past the *fight*, not the *measuring*.
- **The Unmarked Sixth (Dirk's beat — fires before or at initiative).** Dirk carries **no mark**. Maelorn says so aloud and offers the choice: *stand with the marked and be measured*, or *stand aside without quarrel*. Standing with the party = Dirk is tested normally and **counted through the door**. Standing aside = safe, but **no safe-conduct across the seam** (watches from the treeline). Let Ari answer — don't have another player answer for them. Full read-aloud in file 1, Scene 2.
- **Bloodied (≤45 HP)** — the Thorn Ward steps back, plants his glaive, and **kneels**: *"Enough. You are worth the table."* Combat ends.
- **End of Round 3** — even unbloodied, the Thorn Ward calls the test passed (*"You did not break, and you did not kill. Good."*) and yields. Combat ends.
- **Ceremonial Restraint (■■■)** — the Thorn Ward **never drops a PC**. Any hit that would reduce a PC to 0 instead leaves them at **1 HP and prone** ("the flat of the thorn"). Narrate it.
- **Mercy carries over** — if the party *calmed* (rather than killed) the stranded animals in S5's wood-walk, Maelorn knows (the wood tells him) and **opens at advantage to yield** — bloodied threshold ≤55, yields a round early. If S5 ran without that mercy beat, hold to the strict bloodied/R3 triggers.

- **What he carries through the door** — note *how* the party fights (restraint, cleverness, mercy, swagger). **Maelorn walks in with them and reports it to Oberon's face** at the throne (see file 1, Scene 3 — *Maelorn's Verdict* — and file 4's verdict table); it sets the Green Lord's opening warmth. This applies on **every** outcome, the berry shortcut included — the gate always produces a spoken verdict.
- **Avoid: killing the Thorn Ward.** Oberon then receives them as **poachers, not guests** — the harvest in Act Two keeps its hooks but loses its grace (he need not be gracious to meat). Let it cost the tone of the whole second act.
- **Avoid: a PC death.** Ceremonial Restraint should prevent it. If dice get strange, have the Thorn Ward call the test over on the spot — he would rather yield than spill guest-blood.

Tactics Summary

- **Maelorn the Thorn Ward** — R1 deliver the challenge (free), Thorn-Glaive ×2 against the boldest melee PC, pulling the blow. R2 *Bramble Snare* to control the line, glaive the snared. R3 yield (or earlier at bloodied). **Stays between the party and the seam** the entire fight — *Ward of the Gate* means no one crosses until he yields and stands aside.
- **Sprite Outrider 1 & 2** — R1 hover, *Heart-Sight Arrows* at the two most aggressive PCs; any sprite reading "resolve, not malice" shifts to non-lethal. R2 *Sleep-Tipped Arrows* at the highest-output caster (non-lethal). R3 salute and peel off when the Thorn Ward yields. They **do not recognize Dirk** — a Heart-Sight on the orc reads "river-water, no mark, no malice" and gets called down to Maelorn, feeding the Unmarked Sixth beat.

Flag: DM — This is the gate-test S5 set up and never reached

Same courteous-fey shape as the S4 Herald crash and the prepped S5 trial: a knight who will not be embarrassed, two familiar sprites, a hard parley trigger, no PC deaths, no fey deaths. The difference is what's on the far side. Don't let this fight run long or go bloody — the night's weight is in **Act Two**, and you want the table's blood and dice-luck saved for caring about Sela, not for grinding a gatekeeper who was always going to kneel.

Loot / Aftermath

- **No coin, no gear** — this is a rite, not a raid. On his yield, Maelorn **stands aside from the seam** and escorts the party through (Sela included — the door no longer holds her at her old limit).
- If the party **killed** him instead: no escort, no grace; they cross the seam over his body and Oberon greets *poachers* (see Scene 3 tone note). Strongly steer away from this.

Maelorn, the Thorn Ward

A fey knight of the Green Lord's court, armored in bark and bronze, helmed in a crown of living silver branches hung with white blossom. His glaive ends in a single black thorn. His voice is level and old. He has no intention of killing you — and every intention of finding out whether you are worth his lord's table before he opens the door to it.

Fey, Lawful Neutral • CR 5 (1,800 XP) • ■■■ homebrew

AC	17 (bark-and-bronze plate)
HP	90 (12d8 + 36) • Bloodied 45
Speed	30 ft.
STR	16 (+3)

DEX	18 (+4)
CON	16 (+3)
INT	13 (+1)
WIS	16 (+3)
CHA	17 (+3)
Saves	DEX +7, WIS +6, CHA +6
Skills	Athletics +6, Insight +6, Perception +6
Damage Resistances	Bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical weapons not made of cold iron
Condition Immunities	Charmed, frightened
Senses	Darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 16
Languages	Common, Elvish, Sylvan

Traits. *Magic Resistance:* advantage on saves vs. spells and magical effects. *Fey Step (recharge 4–6):* bonus action, teleport up to 30 ft. *Ward of the Gate:* while the Thorn Ward is conscious and within 15 ft. of the seam, no creature can enter the seam — passing it requires dropping or moving him, or his leave. *Ceremonial Restraint (■■):* the Thorn Ward fights to test, not kill — any hit of his that would reduce a creature to 0 HP instead leaves it at **1 HP and prone**. He will not deliver a killing blow.

Actions. *Multiattack:* two Thorn-Glaive attacks. *Thorn-Glaive:* melee, +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., **1d10 + 4 slashing + 1d6 poison** (~13; the poison is a numbing fey toxin, never lethal). *Bramble Snare (recharge 5–6):* thorns erupt in a 15-ft. line; each creature in it makes a **DEX DC 14** save or is **restrained** (escape DC 14 STR, or 5 fire damage frees them).

Bonus Actions. *Fey Step* (see Traits).

Reactions. *Thorn Ward's Parry:* when hit by a melee attack, add **+3 AC** against that attack (may cause it to miss). Once per round.

Round-by-Round Tactics.

Round 1. Free: deliver the challenge aloud (and the Unmarked-Sixth line to Dirk). Glaive ×2 against the boldest melee PC; pull the blow. Hold the seam.

Round 2. *Bramble Snare* across the party's front to control the line. Glaive the snared PC. Parry the hardest incoming hit.

Round 3. Yield. Ground the glaive, kneel, name the party worthy, stand aside from the seam. Combat ends. (Earlier if bloodied.)

On yield. Rises, stands aside, and **escorts the party through the seam** into the court — Sela with them. States nothing of what waits; that is his lord's to say. *Do not kill him* — see Triggers.

Sprite Outrider (×2)

Small fey mounted on fey-touched giant owls — pale gray feathers, starlight pupils. The same two outriders who circled the Greengrass bonfire and shadowed the wood-walk. Their toy-looking bows are not toys.

Fey, Chaotic Neutral • CR 1 (200 XP each)

AC	15 (leather + fey grace)

HP	22 (5d6 + 5)
Speed	10 ft. ground, 60 ft. fly (80 ft. on owl mount)
STR	8 (−1)
DEX	18 (+4)
CON	12 (+1)
INT	14 (+2)
WIS	14 (+2)
CHA	13 (+1)
Skills	Perception +4, Stealth +6
Senses	Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14
Languages	Common, Elvish, Sylvan

Features. *Mounted (Giant Owl):* the owl provides a flying mount; the sprite uses the owl's movement. *Heart-Sight:* as an action, touch a creature OR succeed on a DC 13 ranged shot with a *Heart-Sight Arrow* to read its surface emotional state. If a sprite reads "resolve/curiosity, not malice," that sprite **shifts to non-lethal** for the rest of the encounter.

Actions. *Shortbow:* ranged 40/160, +6 to hit, **1d6 + 4 piercing**. *Sleep-Tipped Arrow* (1/encounter each): ranged 40/160, +6 to hit, **1d6 + 4 piercing**; target makes a **CON DC 12** save or is **incapacitated (drowsy) until the end of its next turn**. Non-lethal. *Heart-Sight Arrow* (1/encounter each): ranged touch 40/160, DC 13 vs AC, 1 piercing on hit, reads the target's surface intent.

Round-by-Round Tactics.

Round 1. Hover 60 ft up. Heart-Sight Arrows at the two most aggressive PCs. Any sprite reading "resolve, not malice" goes non-lethal.

Round 2. Sleep-Tipped Arrows at the loudest-output caster — aiming to *drowse*, not drop.

Round 3. Salute the Thorn Ward's yield and peel off through the seam ahead of the party.

On defeat. A sprite dropped to 0 → the other breaks off and follows the Thorn Ward. They are not here to die for the gate; don't let the party farm them.



Where We Left Off



You are deep in the Living Wood, and the Living Wood is dying around you. A fey lord you have never met **marked four of you** at the Greengrass bonfire and summoned you to his court — *"You are expected in two days. Do not disappoint me by dying."* The mark is a real compulsion; you could not refuse it if you tried.

To find out who he is before you face him, you collected **Sela Wyndmere**, the village healer — who broke down and confessed she has been his courier for **twelve years**. She tied ribbon-knots and left them at a hollow hawthorn for a lord she never saw, never reading the messages, and learned only now that those ribbons were **stitching** — binding the Feywild to your world and letting him **reel the wood inward, a little every year**. Telling you cost her the healing he gave her.

She walked you in. The deeper you went, the more the forest **packed up and left** — color, then birdsong, then warmth — draining in a slow spiral toward one bright point ahead. **Yinu read the truth in it:** the fey are not fleeing the drow. They are being **recalled** — pulled down a drain toward the wood's center, where the lord is gathering them.

Now you stand at that center. Ahead: two great hawthorns arched over a doorway of standing light, the seam to the lord's court, **closing on a clock**. Sela has come as far as she's ever been allowed — and means, for the first time, to go further.

What Now?

- **The door is the only way on** — and a gatekeeper is about to step out of it to find out whether you're worth his lord's table.
- **Do you still have Quillip's berry?** The pixie's little hawthorn token has never been spent. The gate might be exactly what it's for.
- **Quillip is afraid of the door.** She's never gone through it — nobody who does comes back the same, she says. If you want her with you on the far side, you'll have to ask her.
- **Dirk wasn't marked** — he wasn't at the bonfire. The gate will notice. Walking through is a choice he gets to make.
- **Whatever waits past the seam, Sela is walking into it with you** — and she is not telling you everything she means to do.

The Hawthorn Gate



Two ancient hawthorns have grown together into an arch, white with the last blossom in a grey and dying forest. Beneath them the air **stands up like water on its end** — a doorway of green-gold light, the seam to the lord's court, pulled tight and bright and breathing. Seven moss-furred standing stones ring the clearing, each hung with a knot of ribbon: green, white, bone. This is the door Sela carried twelve years of messages toward and was never once let through.

The Green Lord's Court



Through the seam, the dying grey falls away and you stand inside **spring without end** — a hall woven from living hawthorn grown into vaulting arches, white with blossom, warm with a light that has no source, long tables laid with a steaming feast and music just past the edge of a song you almost know. On a throne of antler, root, and grey thorn, before the seam pulled to a single shining thread behind him, the lord of the wood waits — and rises to meet you like family he has wanted to seat for an age.

Oberon, the Green Lord



The lord of the wood, named at last. **Oberon, the Green Lord** — an archfey of the wild green, ancient beyond the dale, crowned in living antler and white blossom, robed in leaf and moss and three trailing ribbons. He is the most gracious host you have ever met: warm, funny, generous, and genuinely glad you came. He thanks you for keeping the drow out of his wood. He learns your names and your gifts. And he offers you a place at his table — *forever, and no winter in it.*

"Stay. Be mine, and be honored, and never grow old or afraid again. Say yes. It is such an easy word."

His smile never falters. That is the frightening part.

Maelorn, the Thorn Ward



The knight who rode a stag into your festival and marked your friends — on foot now, keeping the door. A fey gatekeeper in bark and bronze, helmed in living silver branches, a single black thorn for a glaive-head. He is courteous and old and entirely unafraid, and he tests every guest the Court receives.

"I am Maelorn, Thorn Ward of this gate. My lord has marked you, and the marked are tested before they are met. I will not aim to kill — so do not insult me by dying."

He is not here to kill you. He is here to find out what kind of guests you are — and then to open the door.

Sela Wyndmere — The Last Ribbon



The healer who patched you up all winter, who buried enough scouts to have already chosen Rellan Tessar's burial cloth before you carried him home alive. For twelve years she tied the knots that sewed this wood into the Green Lord's hand — never reading them, telling herself that meant they were clean. At his throne, she reads them at last.

She is the one who tied the binding. She is the only one who can cut it. And the fey healing he loaned her is the thread she has to spend to do it.

"You have years left to grow old badly. I spent mine. Let me spend them well."

Sela's Last Message

(Shown to the players when Sela reads the old knot in Scene 4 — her final gift, the one piece of her legacy not spent by her death.)

As Sela's fingers work the old knot open, she speaks the words aloud — fast, because the hall is coming apart around her:

"The dark ones dig beneath the skull-stone. The masked ones open mouths in the rock; the spider-ones close them. Both are ours to watch, not ours to fight. Hold the green at the river-stone and do not let them past the third cleft. If the stitching holds, the wood holds."

What the party learns:

The "masked ones" are the Vhaeraunians — the drow cell the party fought in Sessions 1–3 (silver half-masks, three staging sites on Old Skull's flanks).

The "spider-ones" are the Lolthites — the rival drow faction purging Vhaeraunian anchors from below (Session 2).

The "third cleft" is a passage **deeper** than the three staging sites the party already cleared — one they have never found.

Oberon's fey wardens were containing the drow — and Sela's ribbons were part of that containment. The stitching is now broken. When the party returns from the Feywild, nothing will be holding that third cleft.

DM Quick Reference — The Green Lord's Court

Session 006 · Print and keep at the table · Full detail in file 1 (adventure) and file 2 (combat)

Scene Order

#	Scene	Key mechanic	DM flag
1	The Last Mile	Reorient at the gate; seam closing on a clock; Sela declares she's crossing	~10 min. Don't re-run S5 — Harper book / Lathander letter / drow clock all off the table tonight
2	The Hawthorn Gate	Encounter 1 — Maelorn's trial; berry shortcut ; Dirk's Unmarked-Sixth choice; Quillip's own-crossing choice	Ends in a yield, never a kill. Maelorn escorts them through (verdict spoken in Scene 3); Sela crosses too
3	The Court Received	Maelorn's verdict → Oberon named ; gracious welcome + per-PC temptation + eternal-table offer ; spot the harvest; agency menu	Do NOT stat or fight Oberon . The lever is the binding, not the lord
4	The Last Ribbon	Help Sela decode the knot ; her goodbye to a PC; Sela's redemptive death cuts the line → seam collapses → party tumbles into the Feywild (with one anchor)	End on the fall . Do not narrate the landing — that's S7's cold open

The Harvest Clock (*replaces a boss fight in Act Two*)

The seam contracting to a point **is** the threat — not a statblock. Track it as a 3-stage clock; advance one stage per "scene beat" in the court (the welcome, the offer, the reveal), and **+1 extra stage if the party attacks Oberon** or tries to force the door.

Stage	State	What the party feels / can do
1	Seam wide; feast laid	Welcome. Can talk, look, refuse, bargain. Hooks set in the mark but slack
2	Seam half-closed	The line draws taut — the four marked feel the pull toward the throne. Tells become visible (the still guests, the children, the filaments)
3	Seam a thread	The line reels. Saying "yes" stops you resisting; doing nothing = gathered. Only the binding can be cut now
0	Seam closes	Whoever is inside is gathered forever — <i>unless the line is cut first</i> (Sela)

- **How to stop it:** **not** combat, **not** the door. **Sela cuts the binding** (Scene 4). The marked cannot out-pull the line; steel does nothing to Oberon.

- **At zero without the cut:** the party is gathered (smiling, still, eternal). Avoid — but the *threat* of it is what makes Sela's choice land. If the table dithers, let Stage 3 squeeze, then have Sela move.

Eat Nothing, Promise Nothing (*fey law cheat-sheet*)

- **Taking the lord's food by your own choice = consenting to be gathered.** Quillip hisses it if no one rolls **Survival/Nature DC 13** or fey-lore.
- **A careless promise is a contract.** Anything the party agrees to, Oberon will hold them to — write it down.
- **Refusing flat is allowed and safe-ish** — Oberon doesn't rage; the line just keeps reeling. Refusal alone does **not** stop the harvest; the cut does.

Encounter 1 — The Hawthorn Gate (*Scene 2*)

6×L6 · ~3,300 adj XP (Medium-to-Hard) · 3 rounds · parley at bloodied/R3 · NO kills either way

Maelorn, the Thorn Ward (CR 5, ■■■) — AC 17 · HP 90 (bloodied 45)

- Glaive ×2: +7, 1d10+4 + 1d6 poison (numbing, never lethal)
- Bramble Snare (rech 5–6): 15-ft line, DEX DC 14 or restrained
- Magic Resistance · Fey Step (rech 4–6) · Parry (+3 AC reaction) · **Ward of the Gate** (no one crosses the seam while he stands)
- **Ceremonial Restraint:** a hit that would drop a PC leaves them at **1 HP + prone** instead. He never kills.

2× Sprite Outrider (CR 1) — AC 15 · HP 22 (*the S4/S5 pair*)

- Shortbow +6, 1d6+4; Sleep-Tipped (CON DC 12 incap 1 rd, non-lethal); Heart-Sight (reads intent → "resolve not malice" = non-lethal)

Round	Thorn Ward	Sprites
1	Challenge + Dirk's choice (free); glaive ×2, pull the blow; hold the seam	Heart-Sight the 2 boldest
2	Bramble Snare the front line; glaive the snared; Parry	Sleep-Tipped the loudest caster
3	Yield — kneel, name them worthy, stand aside	Salute, peel through the seam

Ending the Gate

Outcome	Trigger	Result
Berry shortcut	Nalith presents Quillip's hawthorn berry	Glaive grounded → 1 symbolic round, no combat → through the door. <i>Best outcome. Covers Dirk</i>
Worthy (bloodied)	HP ≤ 45	Kneels, names them worthy → escorts through
Worthy (timer)	End of Round 3	"You did not break, did not kill" → escorts through
Mercy bonus	Calmed the stranded beasts in S5	Yields a round early / bloodied ≤55
Unmarked Sixth	Maelorn stops at Dirk (pre-initiative)	Dirk's choice: stand with the marked (tested + counted through) or stand aside (safe, no crossing). Ari answers, nobody else
Quillip's crossing	After the gate resolves	She's afraid to cross; if any PC invites her, she comes (fey eyes inside the hall + S7 anchor). If not, she stays at the treeline and is gone when they fall. Let the players decide
Killed Thorn Ward	PC kill	Bad. No escort; Oberon greets <i>poachers</i> — Act Two keeps its hooks, loses its grace. Let it cost the tone

*The gate always produces a verdict — even on the berry shortcut. Maelorn still reads the party in the one ceremonial round. Note the word: merciful / clever-wary / berry-vouched / brave / poachers — he speaks it to Oberon's face when they cross (Scene 3), and it sets the lord's opening warmth. The berry buys past the **fight**, not the **measuring**.*

Maelorn's Verdict → Oberon's Read (*spoken aloud, Scene 3*)

Maelorn walks in with the party and reports their measure to Oberon's face — the gate's payoff made tangible. Pick from how they carried themselves; it sets the welcome's warmth:

Verdict	Maelorn says (paraphrase)	Oberon's welcome
Worthy / merciful	"They did not break, did not kill; one stayed my blade with a word."	Warmest — delighted, leans in
Clever / wary	"Quick, careful, trusted nothing — not even the door."	Amused, respectful
Berry-vouched	"They bore your hawthorn's own berry, lord. Vouched by the wood."	Pleased, indulgent ("Of course.")
Poachers (killed Maelorn)	a sprite/Oberon: "They spilled my Ward's blood at my gate."	Thin and cold — courtesy with the velvet off

Oberon — Behavior & The Offer

- **Never not gracious.** Warm, funny, generous, sincere. He is **not lying** — he genuinely thinks being gathered into his eternal court is a kindness. That's the horror.

- **Does not fight.** Attack him and he sighs; the music plays on; **the Harvest Clock jumps a stage.** No statblock — on purpose.
- **The offer:** an eternal place at his table — *"forever, and no winter in it."* Saying yes = consenting to the gather.
- **Per-PC temptation** — each offer-thread *trumps a live hook* (don't relitigate it, just dangle it):

PC	Oberon trumps...
Fiorn	Helbrin's road-tour — <i>"an audience that never tires, never leaves"</i>
Yinu	the Harper cipher — <i>"read every letter that crosses my wood, from the inside"</i>
Naan	the Lathander/Highmoon letter — <i>"never choose between two lights again"</i>
Nalith	the thankless-healer grind — <i>"heal a hall where healing always wins"</i>
Dirk	the rootless raft — <i>"a river that never floods; no one asks where you came from"</i>
Kto (if present)	the closed spider-war — <i>"hunts that never end"</i>

The tells (let the party find them):

Tell	Check	Reveal
The still guests / the children	Insight DC 14 / Perception DC 15	Shadowdale's "taken" are all here — smiling, still, never left
The thread behind the throne	Arcana DC 15	The seam is hooked into the marks; closing reels them in, doesn't send them home
Oberon himself	Insight DC 17	He means it. Refusal won't enrage him; the line is already set

Oberon's Bargain Matrix (*he loves a deal — every deal is a hook*)

Boon	Effect	Cost tier
Safe passage out	He lets them leave	A name, a memory, a season, or a sworn return at the next turning
Release the taken children	They go free	Someone takes their place at the table (← the door Sela walks through)
A true answer	Who/what/why of the harvest	A secret, freely given
Give back the gathered years	—	Refused. The line is set; something pays it out

Write down anything the party promises — *it's real fey contract law and follows them into the Feywild. Stiffing or threatening Oberon: he is unbothered and the clock keeps ticking.*

What the Party CAN Change (*agency inside a fixed climax*)

The *ending* is fixed (Sela cuts, Sela dies, party falls). The *terms* are not — keep these on the table so it never feels like a cutscene:

Lever	How	Payoff
Oberon's S7 disposition	refuse / bargain / threaten / play along + gate verdict	his stance next time the wood and party cross
The taken children go free	bargain for them, or hold the gap Sela's cut opens	their clean escape becomes the party's win, not automatic
What they owe (or refuse to owe)	every bargain = real fey contract	follows them into the Feywild and back
How complete the drow intel is	help Sela decode the knot (below)	full message vs. fragment
Who witnesses Sela	stand with her, a word, Fiorn's <i>Falling</i>	the heart of the night; the log remembers it

Say **yes to clever non-combat plays** (cutting other ribbons, shielding Sela's work, talking a child loose, spending Quillip's banked boon): let them buy a round / free a captive / harden standing. Only **steel on Oberon** never works.

Sela's Sacrifice (*the climax — Scene 4*)

- **Only Sela can cut the line.** She tied the binding; the fey healing he loaned her is the thread she spends to sever it. It **kills her**. She knows.
- **The party cannot save her AND stop the harvest** — say so (Insight / Quillip / Maelorn): *"The line needs a life. There is no third knot."* She refuses any substitution: *"Let me spend them well."*
- **Steer hard toward letting her have it.** If a player *insists* on a heroic swap, it's a table call — but the prepped, far stronger beat is **Sela's death**. Don't let the party "win" their way out of it.
- **What the party CAN do:** stand with her, guard her as the hall resists, **free the children** through the gap she opens, and *witness* her (a word, a hand, Fiorn's song). **Mark who stands with her** — for her, and for the log.
- **Help her read the knot (decode check).** Steady her hands = full read, no roll; or **Arcana/Investigation DC 13** (Yinu/Fiorn) for the *whole* message. Fail / no help = only the **fragment** (*"masked ones... spider-ones... a third cleft they never found—"*); the precise wording (and "river-stone / do not let them past") is theirs **only if a PC helps**.
- **Give Sela a goodbye to a face, not the party.** Aim it at **Nalith** (S4 Greening bond — *"You're the one this wood needed; I was only ever the courier"*); fall back to **Fiorn** (the *Falling* song) or whoever held her hand.
- **Sela's last message (drow-intelligence tie):** as she cuts, Sela reads her old knots for the first time. One message — four years old — is **Oberon's instruction to fey wardens** watching the drow beneath Old Skull. It names the **"masked ones"** (Vhaeraunians) and **"spider-ones"** (Lolthites), and a **"third cleft"** — a deeper passage below the three sites the party cleared (S1–S3) — that fey wardens were holding. The containment is now broken along with the binding. **The party carries this intelligence into the Feywild.** It's Sela's final gift — the one piece of her legacy not spent by her death. Full read-aloud in file 1, Scene 4.
- **Then:** the binding collapses → Oberon's hold breaks → the seam tears wide the wrong way → **the party is pulled through into the Feywild.** Sela is gone.

Endings

Ending	How	Cost / Loose end
The Cut (intended)	Sela severs the binding; party freed	Sela dead ; party hurled into the Feywild (S7); children freed; Oberon cheated but unharmed
Bargained out	Party trades their way past the line before Stage 0	A promise owed to Oberon (real contract); may avert/alter Sela's death — but she'll likely still cut to free the children. Track the debt
Poachers' welcome	They killed Maelorn first	Same Cut ending, but Oberon ungracious throughout; harsher fey-debt going forward
Gathered (failure)	Clock hits 0 with no cut and no deal	Avoid. If it looms, Sela moves on her own. Don't let the kids actually get harvested

Whatever the ending: end on the tumble into the Feywild. Do not narrate the landing — S7 cold open.

Debrief / Carry-Forward

Item	Condition	Note
Contract pay (Ulphor, S5)	—	Owed <i>if they ever get home to collect it</i>
Quillip's berry	If unspent at the gate	Carried into the Feywild — maybe worth more there
Quillip herself	If a PC invited her across	Crossed <i>with</i> the party — frightened, loyal fey ally on a hostile plane; strongest S7 anchor . If not invited, left at the treeline
Strand of the lord's ribbon	If used as the S7 anchor (Scene 4)	Sela's last knotwork, snagged on whoever stood closest; legible to anyone who learns the cipher; <i>guest-right</i> in the Feywild = DM call
Sela's gift	The cut passes through the party	DM-defined S7 boon (lingering healing / fey goodwill)
Sela's last message	Read aloud as she cuts (Scene 4)	Drow intelligence carried into the Feywild: Oberon's fey wardens were containing the drow; the " third cleft " is a deeper passage below S1–S3 sites, now unheld. Sets up the drow situation the party returns to in S7+
Freed children	If the gap was opened	Pour back toward Shadowdale; the party can't escort them (they go the other way)
Milestone	Survived audience + broke harvest + crossed over	Earned → apply between sessions (toward L7). No table level-up

Tone / Staging Beats

- Open **at the gate**, mid-stride from where S5 cut — no travel montage, the wood is already grey.
- The gate fight is a **question, not a slaughter** — Maelorn pulls every blow; save the table's blood for Act Two.
- The court should feel **wonderful first** — warmth, music, a feast, a host who loves them — *then* wrong. Don't tip the harvest early; let them find the children.
- **Oberon stays gracious through everything**, even the cut. "*The courier reads at last.*" No villain rant.
- **Sela's death is the night**. Slow down. Let players stand with her. **Give her last words to a face (Nalith first)**. Let it hurt.
- **Make agency visible**. The ending is fixed; the *terms* aren't — children, promises, the decoded message, who witnesses her. Say yes to clever non-combat plays.
- **End on the fall** — brightness, wrongness, together, falling. Cut to black. "*You'll find out when you land.*"

Loose Ends to Flag in Session Log After Play

(Tick after the session; fold into campaign/session-log.md on the post-play update — not before.)

- [] **The gate** — berry shortcut, fought-to-yield, or killed Maelorn? How did the party measure?
- [] **Dirk** — stood with the marked and crossed, or stood aside?
- [] **The Green Lord is named — Oberon**. Canon now. How did the party take the reveal / the offer?
- [] **Did the party refuse, bargain, or attack?** Record any **promises made to Oberon** (real fey debt → S7).
- [] **The taken children** — freed, or still gathered?
- [] **Quillip** — invited across (now in the Feywild with the party) or left at the treeline? Record it — it sets her S7 status.
- [] **The S7 anchor** — what fell through with them (Quillip, the ribbon strand, both)? Note it for the S7 cold open.
- [] **Sela Wyndmere is dead** (redemptive). Who stood with her? **Who got her goodbye?** → flip her roster status to *deceased*; close her arc in the log.
- [] **Was the last message fully decoded** (PC helped) or only the fragment? Record how complete the drow intel the party carries is.
- [] **Sela's last message — drow intelligence**. The party now knows Oberon's fey wardens were containing the drow beneath Old Skull, and a "**third cleft**" (deeper than the S1–S3 staging sites) is now unheld. Track this as a live thread for S7+ — the drow situation will be worse when the party returns. Cross-link campaign/factions.md § Drow and § Fey.
- [] **The party crossed into the Feywild** — set the S7 cold open (where do they land?).
- [] **Oberon survives, un-fought, court unmade** — disposition toward the party going forward.
- [] **The wood is greening again** — Shadowdale will feel the recall reverse while the PCs are gone.
- [] **Still live, untouched tonight**: Yinu's Harper book, Naan's Lathander letter, Helbrin's tour offer, the Vhaeraunian retaliation clock, Quillip's quarter-moon riddle.

Timing Budget

Block	Target	Slip-tolerance
The Last Mile (Scene 1)	10 min	Cap at 15; the door is the magnet
The Hawthorn Gate (Scene 2)	35 min	Berry shortcut saves ~15 min
The Court Received (Scene 3)	35 min	The welcome + offer + finding the tells
The Last Ribbon (Scene 4)	25 min	Don't rush Sela. Cut the instant they fall
Total	~1:45–2:00	One short fight, one long table. End on the fall — don't start the Feywild

DM Don'ts

- **Don't** stat or fight Oberon. He's an archfey; the lever is the binding, not the lord.
- **Don't** kill Maelorn (and don't let him kill a PC — Ceremonial Restraint catches it).
- **Don't** let the party "save" Sela out of her sacrifice — steer hard; it's the heart of the night.
- **Don't** narrate where they land in the Feywild. End on the fall. S7 owns the cold open.
- **Don't** re-run Session 5's loose threads — Harper book, Lathander letter, drow clock all wait.
- **Don't** tip the harvest before the party finds the children — let the welcome be genuinely lovely first.
- **Don't** stage a level-up. Milestone is earned, applied between sessions.